

INDIAN MEN PITCH IN 16 hours A WEEK IN HOUSEWORK, UP FROM 1.2 HOURS IN 1965

BHASKAR PAUL



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PARTNER, AMARCHAND MANGALDAS, MUMBAI
He tries his best to bond with his daughter, Sivaranjani, despite his 14-hour workdays. But she thinks he's never there.

“It's painful when my daughter clings to me to stop me from going to work.”

up differently, they were conditioned to look at childcare as a woman's job, they received no training in fathering, and they are confused about the long-term effects of adopting modern ways.” Studies show how conflicting ideas of parental roles within the family create further confusion. Sociologist G.N. Ramu of the University of Manitoba in the US has analysed how for many Indian women allowing a man to take up childcare violates their self-image as competent mothers and wives. In 2005, when Sriram interviewed 50 parents in Baroda, 38 per cent cited job context (lack of time, work pressure) for not being an active parent; 30 per cent mentioned “unsuitable temperament” and “lack of skills” to be an effective father; 21 per cent rooted for the fathers' tendency to “escape from certain tasks” easily.

What cuts away the ground beneath men's feet further is the entry of women in the workforce. For every five men, there is one woman who works in an income-generating activity in urban India today. Having two incomes may have brought economic benefits to countless families and given women opportunities for fulfilment, but it has left men scrambling to become the full-fledged co-parents their wives now need them to be. A study shows that

Indian men today pitch in 16 hours a week in housework—up from 1.2 hours in 1965. But the real crunch lies elsewhere for professional couples with matching incomes. “The sense of masculinity, more than fathering, goes up for re-negotiation,” says Chopra. Take Chakrawarti and his wife Raka, a PR professional. While she believes he should spend more time with their child, he thinks he does his best: “My wife may not agree with me, but I play with my daughter, read her stories and take her out whenever I can.”

“Whenever I can” is the operative phrase and professional economist, Omkar Goswami, feels most dads are overstretched because they don't know how to prioritise their time. “Even at Infosys, which is known for its productivity, 95 per cent of men leave office by 7.30 p.m.,” says the man who figures on the board of directors of the company. “The legendary Narayana Murthy, founder of Infosys, always had the time to mentor his daughter's education.” It also has to do with the New Age notion of ‘the complete man’, feels professor Mangesh Kulkarni of the University of Pune, who's also the convener of the Forum for the Study of Men & Masculinities. There is a greater “civil privatism” in men's lives today—a withdrawal into the shell of

private, family life and activities centred on shopping and consumption, rather than public engagements on which men used to spend a good deal of their time and energy earlier.”

Yet, for most fathers, salvation lies in the world of work. While the concept of progressive programmes is catching up worldwide, there is no law in force in India which entitles a father to balance work and home. A random check reveals that most corporates grant paternity leave for as little as two days to a maximum of three months. But already there are murmurs of change. HSBC bank has initiated measures—childcare centres to flexi hours to longer paternity leave. NDTV is a rare media company that provides for crèches. The IT sector, home to the ‘best employers’ in India, is pushing for incentive packages, which include paternity leave. Some, like ABB, include fathering in social responsibility agenda.

The easiest formula for men to improvise ways of boosting the time they spend with their children is to learn from their working spouse and be more like a woman. A tough call in a macho Indian society, made tougher in today's highly competitive work culture, where staying late at work is considered a sign of an employee's status and importance in a company. For most dads it's the menopause syndrome all over again—does he pause at work and spend more time at home or will that mean losing out on the fatter paycheck, the fancier car, the promotion? Till that dilemma is resolved, the tribe of Transient Confused Fathers can only increase.

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